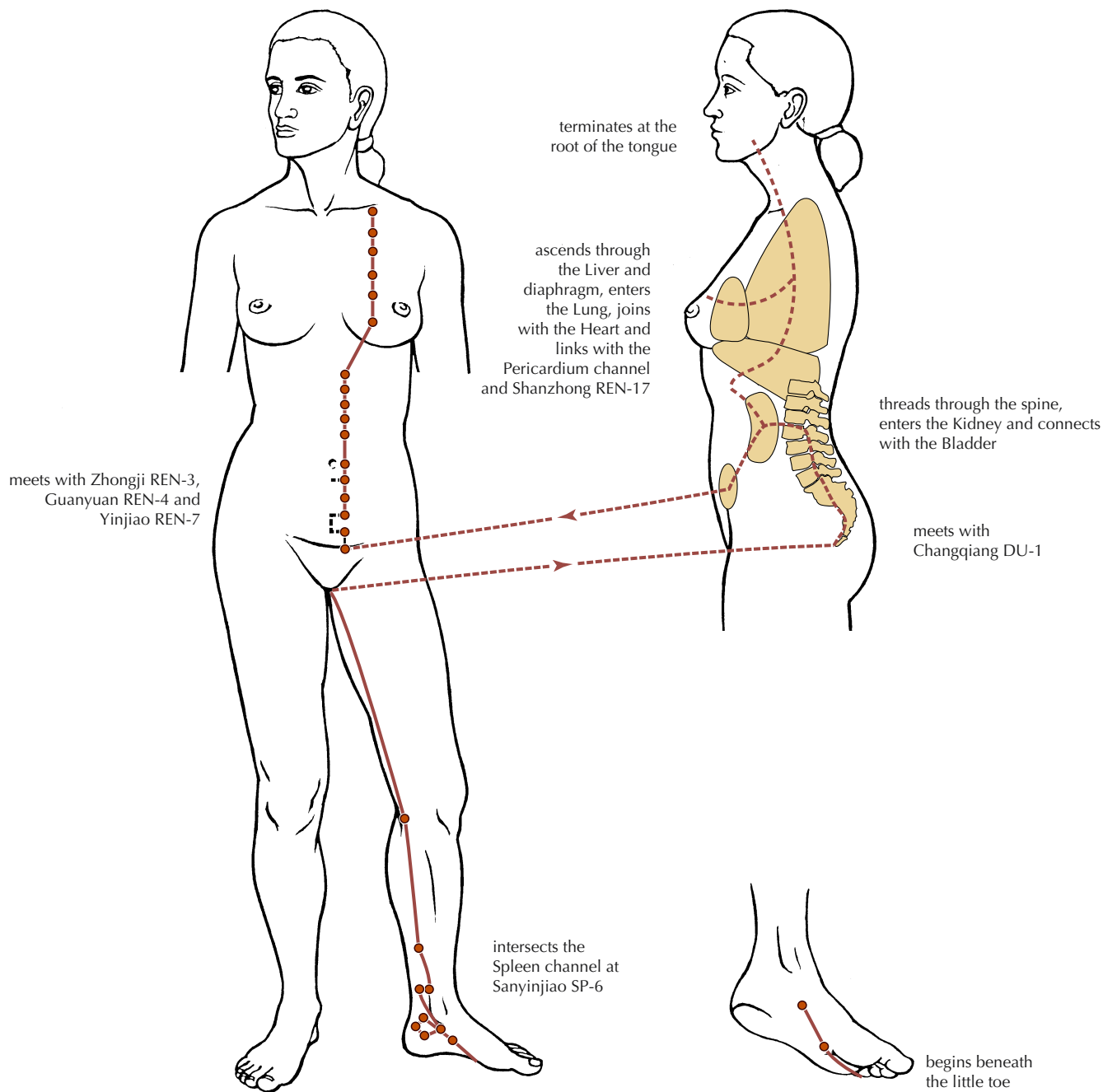

足少陰腎經

THE KIDNEY CHANNEL
OF FOOT SHAOYIN

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THE KIDNEY PRIMARY CHANNEL

- begins beneath the little toe,
- crosses the sole of the foot to Yongquan KID-1,
- emerges at Rangu KID-2, anterior and inferior to the navicular tuberosity,
- travels posterior to the medial malleolus at Taixi KID-3 where it descends through the heel and then ascends to below the medial malleolus at Zhaohai KID-6,
- ascends along the medial aspect of the leg, intersecting the Spleen channel at Sanyinjiao SP-6,
- continues up the leg to the medial side of the popliteal fossa at Yingu KID-10 and along the postero-medial aspect of the thigh to the tip of the coccyx where it intersects with the Governing vessel at Changqiang DU-1
- threads its way through the spine, enters the Kidney and connects with the Bladder,
- intersects the Conception vessel at Zhongji REN-3, Guanyuan REN-4 and Yinjiao REN-7,

- one branch emerges from the Kidney, ascends through the Liver and diaphragm, enters the Lung and ascends along the throat to terminate at the root of the tongue,
- another branch separates in the Lung, joins with the Heart and disperses in the chest to link with the Pericardium channel and Shanzhong REN-17.

The Kidney primary channel connects with the following zangfu: Kidney, Bladder, Liver, Lung, Heart.

The Kidney primary channel meets with other channels at the following points: Sanyinjiao SP-6 Changqiang DU-1, Zhongji REN-3, Guanyuan REN-4, Yinjiao REN-7, Shanzhong REN-17.

THE KIDNEY DIVERGENT CHANNEL

- separates from the Kidney primary channel in the popliteal fossa,
- intersects the Bladder divergent channel on the thigh,
- ascends to connect with the Kidneys,
- crosses the Girdling vessel in the region of the second lumbar vertebra,
- ascends to the root of the tongue,
- continues upwards to emerge at the nape of the neck and converge with the Bladder primary channel.

THE KIDNEY LUO-CONNECTING CHANNEL

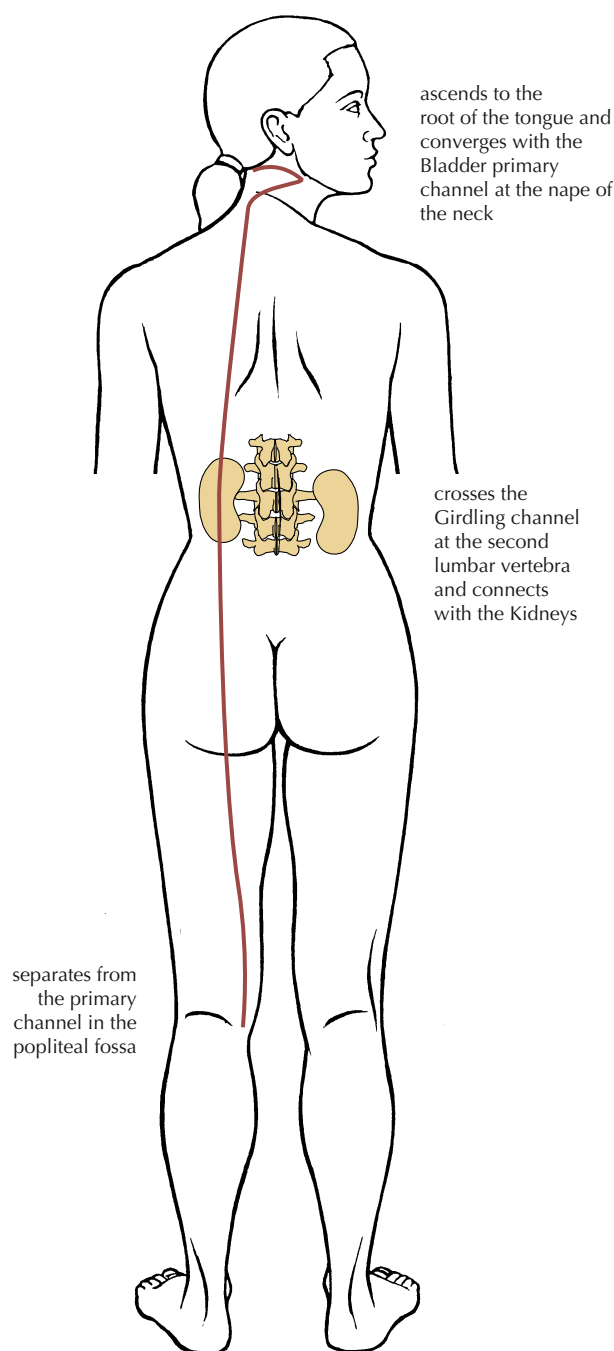
- begins at Dazhong KID-4 on the posterior aspect of the medial malleolus,
- encircles the heel and enters internally to connect with the Bladder channel,
- ascends along with the Kidney primary channel from Dazhong KID-4 to a point below the Pericardium where it travels posteriorly to and spreads into the lumbar vertebrae.

THE KIDNEY SINEW CHANNEL

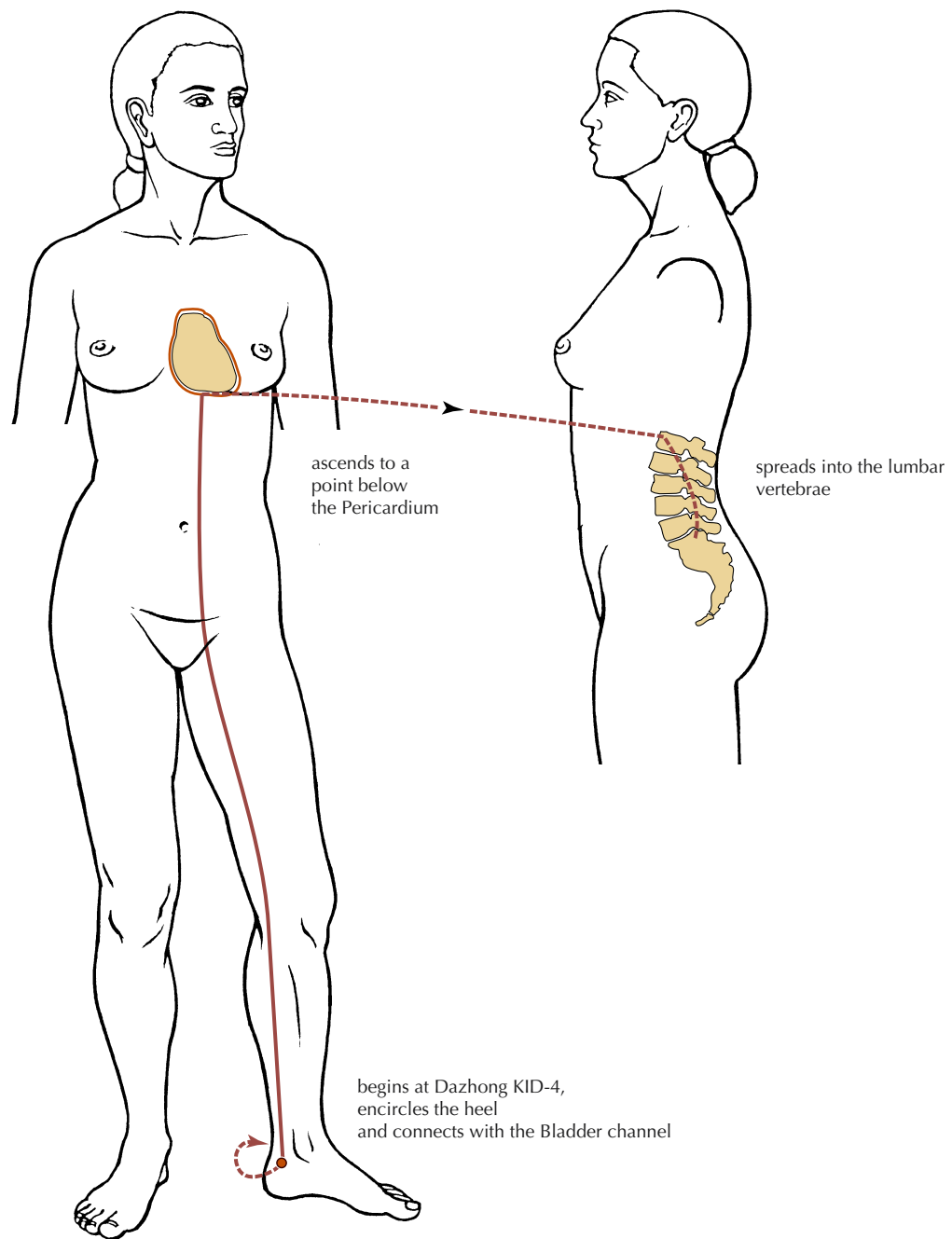
- begins beneath the little toe and joins the Spleen sinew channel at the inferior aspect of the medial malleolus,
- binds in the heel where it converges with the Bladder sinew channel, then ascends the leg and binds at the medial condyle of the tibia,
- joins with the Spleen sinew channel and follows the medial surface of the thigh to bind at the genitals.

A branch

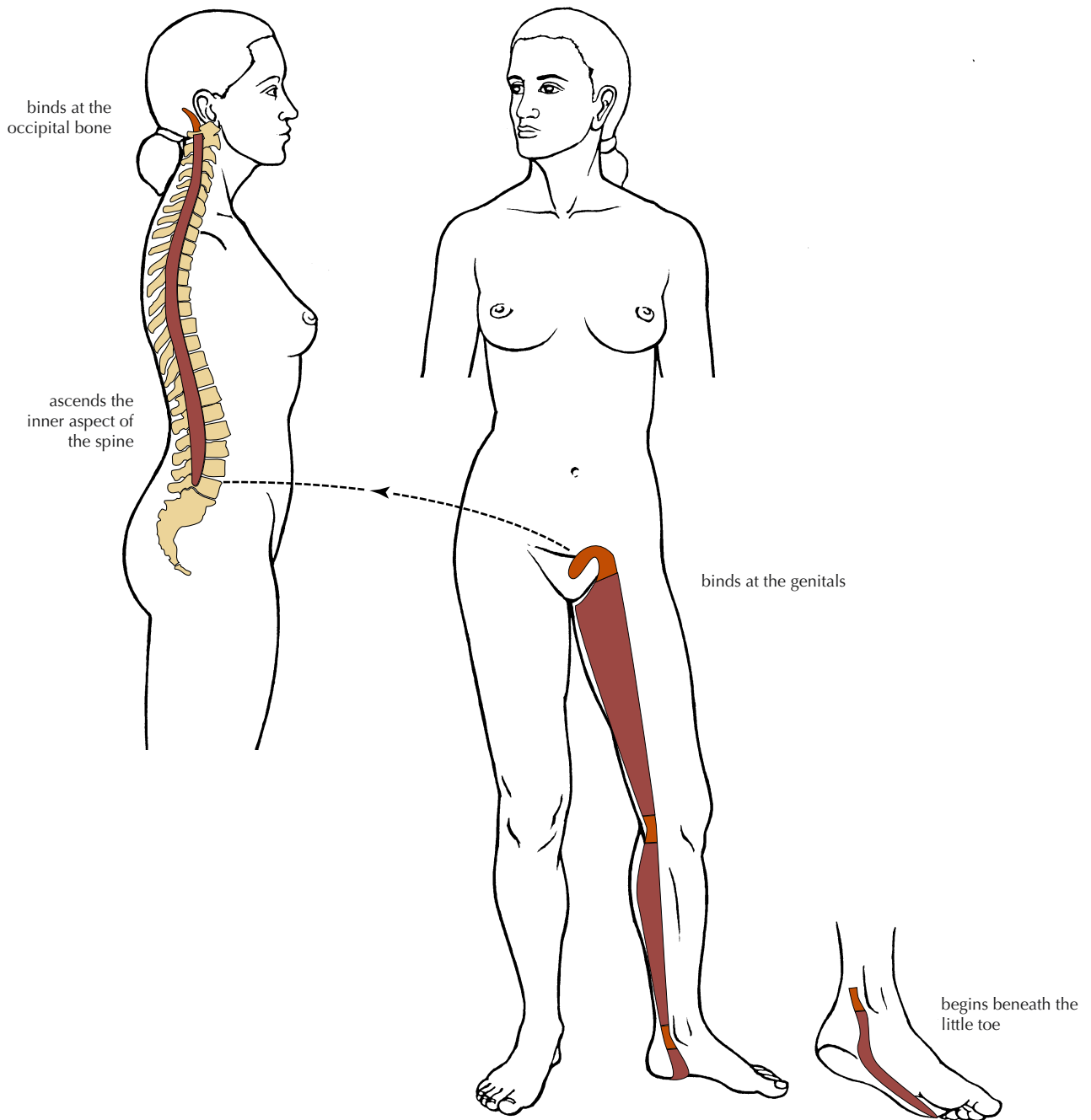
- travels internally to the spinal vertebrae, ascends the inner aspect of the spine to the nape of the neck where the channel binds to the occipital bone, and converges with the Bladder sinew channel.



The Kidney divergent channel



The Kidney Luo-connecting channel



The Kidney sinew channel

Pathological symptoms of the Kidney sinew channel

Cramping of the bottom of the foot, cramping and pain along the course of the channel, convulsion and spasm associated with epilepsy. If the disease is on the exterior the patient cannot bend forward, if the disease

is on the interior the patient cannot bend backwards. Thus in a yang disorder there will be inability to bend the lumbar spine forwards, whilst in a yin disorder here will be inability to bend the lumbar spine backwards.

DISCUSSION

The Kidney channel of foot shaoyin is interiorly-exteriorly coupled with the Bladder channel, and paired with the Heart channel of hand shaoyin according to six channel theory. The Kidney-Bladder relationship is further strengthened by the fact that:

- the interior pathway of the Kidney primary channel connects with the Bladder fu.
- the Kidney luo-connecting channel connects with the Bladder channel.
- the Kidney divergent channel intersects the Bladder channel on the thigh.

In addition, it is important to note that:

- the Kidney primary channel intersects the Conception vessel at Zhongji REN-3 and Guanyuan REN-4.
- the Kidney primary channel ascends through the Liver, diaphragm, Lung and Heart.
- the Kidney primary channel ascends through the throat.
- the Kidney primary and divergent channels ascend to the root of the tongue.
- the Kidney primary, luo-connecting and sinew channels spread into the spine.
- the Kidney sinew channel, but not the Kidney primary channel, ascends to the genitals.

The Kidneys have five principal functions:

- storing essence and dominating reproduction, growth and development.
- producing marrow, filling up the brain, dominating bones and assisting in the production of blood.
- dominating water.
- controlling the reception of qi.
- opening into the ears and dominating the two lower yin (the anus and urethra).

In addition, the Kidneys:

- are the lowest zang.
- are the root of the original yin and yang of the body.
- conserve and control the ming men fire.
- house the will.
- are the foundation of the Conception and Penetrating vessels which originate in the uterus, whilst according to the *Essential Questions*¹ “the vessel of the uterus connects with the Kidneys”.

It is by virtue of these functions and relationships, as well as the channel pathways discussed above, that many of the actions and indications of the points of the Kidney channel can be explained. These can be summarised as:

- rooting pathologically ascending heat, qi, yang and wind. The Kidneys are the bottommost zang and the root of the yin in the body. When yin is deficient, deficiency heat, or uprising yang or interior wind may ascend to the throat, ears, eyes and head. Points of the Kidney channel are frequently used clinically both to nourish yin (e.g. Taixi KID-3) and to strongly descend pathogens from the head (e.g. Yongquan KID-1).
- nourishing yin and clearing deficiency heat in the treatment of night sweating, wasting and thirsting disorder etc.
- nourishing Liver yin to counteract uprising of Liver yang in the treatment of headache, dizziness etc.
- nourishing Kidney water to balance excessive Heart fire, and harmonising the will and the spirit in the treatment of restlessness, insomnia, poor memory, palpitations, epilepsy, mania, susceptibility to fright etc.
- rooting the qi and harmonising the relationship between the Kidneys and Lung in the treatment of cough, coughing of blood, dyspnoea, asthma, wheezing etc.
- tonifying Kidney yang to strengthen the Kidney function of dominating water in the treatment of oedema and deficiency type urinary disorders.
- tonifying Kidney yang to strengthen the libido in the treatment of impotence, seminal emission etc.
- tonifying Kidney yang to warm the lower body, legs and feet.
- benefiting the throat, especially in the treatment of sore and dry throat or loss of voice due to yin deficiency.
- strengthening the lumbar spine and benefiting the teeth.
- benefiting the ears in the treatment of tinnitus and deafness.
- regulating the Conception and Penetrating vessels and treating diseases of the uterus such as infertility, disordered menstruation, uterine prolapse, post-partum disorders etc.
- draining damp-heat from the lower jiao and regulating the function of the Bladder and intestines in the treatment of difficult urination, retention of urine, painful urinary dysfunction, dark urine, diarrhoea, dysenteric disorder, swelling, itching and pain of the genitals, shan disorder, hypogastric pain etc.
- nourishing Kidney yin in the treatment of constipation due to dryness.